women were listed as having suckled Akbar, including one Hindu woman, Bibi Rupa. In charge of all these women was Maham Anaga, the superintendent of the milk nurses, who also had with her Adham Khan, her ten-year-old son. All these women and children would surround Akbar with fierce love and careful tenderness and many would walk alongside him, sharing his destiny, far into the future. Some had blazing careers at his court and one, Jiji Anaga, was so loved by Akbar that at her death, half a century later, his grief for her would be more extravagant than that for any other woman save his own mother.

A summons soon arrived from the eager Humayun who had pitched camp in a large garden in the town of Jun in Sind and, when Akbar was less than two months old, the Mughal party departed from Umerkot. Hamida Banu travelled with her baby in a litter, described by a later traveller as a ‘takht revan’, a wooden box with latticed sides, covered with hides and fixed upon two poles which were carried by mules. The party arrived in Jun on 20 December 1542, and Humayun’s many hardships must have felt somewhat diminished when he took his son in his arms for the first time and kissed him on the forehead. The Mughal party remained in Jun for a few months, all the while losing supporters who left brazenly in a show of bad humour or skulked away in secrecy. Even more worrying was news that Kamran and Askari were jointly planning to conquer Kandahar, at that point held in Humayun’s name by Hindal. Hindal, most amenable of Humayun’s brothers, beloved of his sisters, was known to be easily influenced by his brothers. There was, however, occasion for rejoicing when one of Babur’s soldiers from the Turkoman Qaraqoyunlu clan, Bairam Khan, came to join forces with Humayun. The Padshah, it was reported, was ‘much rejoiced by the arrival of so celebrated a character’. And, indeed, the fortuitous reappearance of this talented general and shrewd strategist would ensure the future of the empire. But desperate now for the support of his brothers, Humayun turned to the one person he believed might still hold some sway over these recalcitrant siblings, his aunt and eldest kinswoman, Khanzada Begum. So, at the age of sixty-four, Khanzada Begum bravely made the journey north through almost a thousand miles of rough terrain, marauders, and enemies, to reason with her nephews in the name of her brother, the Padshah Babur.

By this time, the Governor of Sind had grown tired of his unwelcome guest and, in July 1543, the Mughal cortège headed towards Kandahar. ‘The